

The Rise of Nationalism in Europe

Social Science - Class 10

Introduction: The Dream of a United Europe

In 1848, a French artist named Frédéric Sorrieu created a series of four prints that beautifully visualised his dream of a world made up of 'democratic and social republics'. His first print shows the peoples of Europe and America marching in a long train, offering homage to the Statue of Liberty as they pass by it. The Statue of Liberty is personified as a female figure holding the torch of Enlightenment in one hand and the Charter of the Rights of Man in the other. Sorrieu's utopian vision shows different nations, identified through their flags and national costumes, marching towards a unified future. Leading the procession are the United States and Switzerland, followed by France and Germany. The German people were not yet a united nation, so the flag they carry represents the hopes of the liberal nationalists in 1848 to create a unified German state. Following Germany are the people of Austria, the Kingdom of the Two Sicilies, Lombardy, Poland, England, Ireland, Hungary, and Russia. From the heavens above, Christ, saints, and angels gaze upon the scene. They have been used by the artist to symbolise fraternity and brotherhood among the nations of the world.

This chapter will explore the various issues that were visualised by Sorrieu in his utopian print. During the nineteenth century, nationalism emerged as a powerful force that brought about huge changes in the political and mental world of Europe. The final result of these changes was the emergence of the 'nation-state' in place of the multi-national dynastic empires of Europe. A nation-state is a state in which the majority of its citizens, and not just its rulers, came to develop a shared sense of identity and common history. This sense of shared identity and history was not present from time immemorial but was forged through struggles, through the actions of leaders, and through common people. The French Revolution of 1789 is a key event in understanding the emergence of nationalism. We will now look at how this idea of nationalism developed.

- Frédéric Sorrieu, a French artist, visualised a world of 'democratic and social republics' in a series of four prints in 1848.
- His first print depicted the peoples of Europe and America marching towards the Statue of Liberty, symbolising freedom and rights.

- Nationalism, a strong force in the 19th century, led to the formation of nation-states, replacing dynastic empires.
- The French Revolution of 1789 was a pivotal event that spread the ideals of nationalism across Europe.

The French Revolution and the Idea of the Nation

The French Revolution of 1789 marked the first clear expression of nationalism. It was a political and constitutional upheaval that led to the transfer of sovereignty from the monarchy to a body of French citizens. The revolution declared that it was the people who would henceforth constitute the nation and shape its destiny. From the very beginning, the revolutionaries introduced various measures and practices that could create a sense of collective identity among the French people. The ideas of 'la patrie' (the fatherland) and 'le citoyen' (the citizen) emphasised the notion of a united community enjoying equal rights under a constitution.

A new French flag, the tricolour, was chosen to replace the former royal standard. The Estates General was elected by the body of active citizens and was renamed the National Assembly. New hymns were composed, oaths were taken, and martyrs were commemorated, all in the name of the nation. A centralised administrative system was put in place, and it formulated uniform laws for all citizens within its territory. Internal customs duties and dues were abolished, and a uniform system of weights and measures was adopted. Regional dialects were discouraged, and French, as it was spoken and written in Paris, became the common language of the nation.

The revolutionaries further declared that it was the mission and the destiny of the French nation to liberate the peoples of Europe from despotism and to help other peoples become nations. When the news of the events in France reached the cities of Europe, students and other members of the educated middle classes began setting up Jacobin clubs. Their activities and campaigns prepared the way for the French armies, which moved into Holland, Belgium, Switzerland, and much of Italy in the 1790s. With the outbreak of the revolutionary wars, the French armies began to carry the idea of nationalism abroad.

- The French Revolution was the first major expression of nationalism, transferring power from the monarch to the people.

- Ideas like 'la patrie' (the fatherland) and 'le citoyen' (the citizen) created a collective identity.
- Changes included a new tricolour flag, a centralised administration, uniform laws, and the promotion of French as a national language.
- The French armies spread the idea of nationalism to other parts of Europe, inspiring the formation of Jacobin clubs.

Napoleon's Rule and the Napoleonic Code

Although Napoleon Bonaparte destroyed democracy in France by returning to a monarchy, he incorporated revolutionary principles in the administrative field to make the whole system more rational and efficient. The Civil Code of 1804, also known as the Napoleonic Code, did away with all privileges based on birth. It established equality before the law and secured the right to property. This code was exported to the regions under French control, such as the Dutch Republic, Switzerland, Italy, and Germany. In these areas, Napoleon simplified administrative divisions, abolished the feudal system, and freed peasants from serfdom and manorial dues.

In the towns too, guild restrictions were removed. Transport and communication systems were improved. Peasants, artisans, workers, and new businessmen enjoyed this new-found freedom. Businessmen and small-scale producers of goods, in particular, realised that uniform laws, standardised weights and measures, and a common national currency would facilitate the movement and exchange of goods and capital from one region to another. However, the initial enthusiasm for French rule soon turned to hostility. The newly conquered areas found that the French administrative arrangements did not go hand-in-hand with political freedom. Increased taxation, censorship, and forced conscription into the French armies required to conquer the rest of Europe all seemed to outweigh the advantages of the administrative changes. Napoleon's quest for expansion and his autocratic rule ultimately led to widespread opposition.

- Napoleon's Civil Code of 1804 (Napoleonic Code) abolished birth-based privileges, established equality before the law, and secured property rights.
- He simplified administrative divisions, abolished the feudal system, and freed peasants in the territories he controlled.

- Uniform laws and standardised systems of weights and measures benefited businessmen and the economy.
- Initial enthusiasm for Napoleon's rule faded due to increased taxation, censorship, and forced conscription, which were seen as oppressive.

The Making of Nationalism in Europe

In mid-18th-century Europe, there were no 'nation-states' as we know them today. Germany, Italy, and Switzerland were divided into kingdoms, duchies, and cantons whose rulers had their own autonomous territories. Eastern and Central Europe were under autocratic monarchies, which ruled over diverse peoples. These diverse groups did not see themselves as sharing a collective identity or a common culture. For example, the Habsburg Empire, which ruled over Austria-Hungary, was a patchwork of many different regions and peoples. It included the German-speaking aristocracy in the Alpine regions and Bohemia, while the Magyar-speaking population lived in Hungary and the Polish-speaking aristocracy resided in Galicia. Such differences did not easily promote a sense of political unity. The only bond tying these diverse groups together was a common allegiance to the emperor.

Nationalism and the idea of the nation-state emerged from the complex interplay of several factors. One of the most significant was the rise of a new middle class. In Western and parts of Central Europe, the growth of industrial production and trade meant the growth of towns and the emergence of commercial classes. These classes were made up of industrialists, businessmen, and professionals. They were educated and liberal and believed that a nation-state was the only solution to the problems of a divided Europe. They championed the ideals of liberalism, which stood for freedom for the individual and equality of all before the law. Politically, liberalism meant government by consent and the end of autocracy. Economically, liberalism meant the freedom of markets and the abolition of state-imposed restrictions on the movement of goods and capital.

- In mid-18th century Europe, there were no nation-states; countries were divided into small kingdoms and empires with diverse populations.
- The Habsburg Empire is a prime example of a multi-ethnic, multi-lingual empire with little sense of a shared identity.
- The rise of a new, educated middle class—comprising industrialists, businessmen, and

professionals—was crucial to the spread of nationalism.

- This middle class advocated for liberalism, which meant individual freedom, equality before the law, and free markets, paving the way for the nation-state.

New Conservatism After 1815

Following the defeat of Napoleon in 1815, European governments were driven by a spirit of conservatism. Conservatives believed that established traditional institutions of state and society—like the monarchy, the Church, social hierarchies, property, and the family—should be preserved. However, most conservatives were not in favour of a return to the society of pre-revolutionary days. They had realised, from the changes initiated by Napoleon, that modernisation could, in fact, strengthen traditional institutions. They believed that a modern army, an efficient bureaucracy, a dynamic economy, and the abolition of feudalism and serfdom could strengthen the autocratic monarchies of Europe. This belief was held by conservatives at the time, and it meant that they could accept some changes, but only if they served to bolster their traditional power structures.

In 1815, representatives of the European powers—Britain, Russia, Prussia, and Austria—who had collectively defeated Napoleon, met at Vienna to draw up a settlement for Europe. The congress was hosted by the Austrian Chancellor, Duke Metternich. The delegates drew up the Treaty of Vienna of 1815, with the main objective of undoing most of the changes that had come about in Europe during the Napoleonic wars. The Bourbon dynasty, which had been deposed during the French Revolution, was restored to power, and France lost the territories it had annexed under Napoleon. A series of states were set up on the boundaries of France to prevent French expansion in the future. The Kingdom of the Netherlands, including Belgium, was set up in the north, and Genoa was added to Piedmont in the south. Prussia was given important new territories on its western frontiers, while Austria was given control of Northern Italy. The German confederation of 39 states that had been set up by Napoleon was left untouched. In the east, Russia was given part of Poland, while Prussia was given a portion of Saxony.

The main intention of this treaty was to restore the monarchies that Napoleon had overthrown and to create a new conservative order in Europe. Conservative regimes set up in 1815 were autocratic. They did not tolerate criticism and dissent and sought to curb activities that questioned the legitimacy of autocratic governments. Most of them imposed

censorship laws to control what was said in newspapers, books, plays, and songs and reflected the ideas of liberty and freedom associated with the French Revolution. The memory of the French Revolution, however, continued to inspire liberals. One of the major issues taken up by the liberal-nationalists who criticised the new conservative order was freedom of the press.

- After Napoleon's defeat in 1815, European governments adopted conservatism, aiming to preserve traditional institutions like monarchy and the Church.
- The Treaty of Vienna of 1815 was created to reverse Napoleonic changes, restore monarchies, and prevent French expansion.
- The Bourbon dynasty was restored, and new states were created around France as a buffer. The German Confederation of 39 states remained.
- Conservative regimes were autocratic, censoring dissent and criticism, but the ideals of the French Revolution continued to inspire liberal-nationalists.

